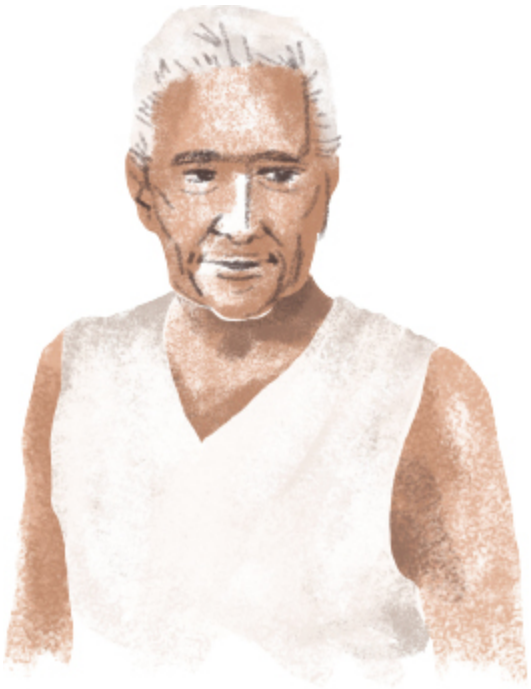


“I DON’T WANT TO BE A GREAT LEADER. I WANT TO BE A MAN WHO GOES AROUND WITH A LITTLE OIL CAN AND WHEN HE SEES A BREAKDOWN OFFERS HIS HELP. TO ME, THE MAN WHO DOES THAT IS GREATER THAN ANY HOLY MAN IN SAFFRON-COLOURED ROBES.”

A conflicted life

Murlidhar Devidas Amte was born into a wealthy Brahmin landowning family in Warora, Maharashtra. Amte graduated with a law degree from Nagpur University in 1936 and set up a successful practice. He had long been uncomfortable with caste-based social segregation, poverty and income inequality, and this discomfort grew stronger as his career prospered. In 1940, he chose to return to his home district, to work towards social change and began organizing workers into unions, to try to improve their wages and working conditions. He also stood for election and took office as the vice-president of the Warora municipality, believing he could